

KEY FIGURE

HORATIO NELSON

1758–1805

Nelson was a fearless and often insubordinate British admiral who was brought to prominence by a bold manoeuvre at Cape St Vincent, in 1797. His victories at the Nile (1798), Copenhagen (1801), and Trafalgar (1805) made him a national hero.



▲ Nelson lost an arm, and the sight in one eye, while leading from the front. He died on board HMS *Victory*.



KEY DEVELOPMENT

NAVAL BATTLES IN THE AGE OF SAIL

By the early 1800s, naval power had become a crucial concern for European powers ruling overseas empires. Substantial resources were devoted to sailing ship fleets, heavily armed with muzzle-loading, smoothbore cannon.

The basic tactics and technology for sailing-ship warfare were established in the 17th century, and did not fundamentally alter until the end of the age of sail in the mid-19th century. Cannon were mounted in broadside (along the ship's sides) and fleets fought in line, side-on to the enemy. Shots were aimed either at the hull, to cause maximum damage to the ship and crew, or at the masts and rigging to disable the vessel. However, wooden

ships were almost impossible to sink with solid shot, and explosive shells were considered too dangerous for use at sea. As a result, engagements ended only when a ship was taken by boarding, or when a captain surrendered to avoid further carnage.

THE AGE OF THE WARSHIP

By this period, navies consisted entirely of purpose-built warships. The role of raiding an enemy's merchant ships, once filled by privateers, was now allotted to naval frigates. The French, who tended to lead in ship design, introduced the classic frigate in 1740, a fast-sailing vessel with a single gundeck mounting at least 28 cannon. Ships of the line were either 74- or 80-gun vessels, with two or three decks and 100 cannon or more. To put this in

▼ NOCK VOLLEY GUN

Volley guns were used in ship-to-ship fighting during the Napoleonic Wars. This model proved to be unwieldy due to the powerful recoil caused by seven barrels firing simultaneously.

